

Ξενοφάνης ὁ Κολοφώνιος

Xenophanes of Colophon on Gods and Nature

eul_aid: beu

Period: Ἀρχαϊκή [Archaic](#)
Dialect: Ἰωνική [Ionic \(frg\)](#)
Domain: Φιλοσοφία [Philosophy](#)
Format: Ἑμμετρος [Verse](#)
Affiliation: [Presocratic](#)

Xenophanes of Colophon was a Greek poet and thinker who lived in the 6th and 5th centuries BCE. Born in Ionia, he left his homeland as a young man and spent most of his long life traveling and performing his poetry throughout the Greek world, eventually settling in Sicily and southern Italy. He is traditionally grouped among the earliest philosophers known as the Presocratics.

His surviving work consists of fragments of poems, which include satirical verses, elegies, and philosophical speculations. In these works, he is best known for his radical criticism of traditional Greek religion. He argued that the gods of Homer and Hesiod were imagined in human form, and instead proposed a single, supreme deity unlike mortals in body or thought.

He also offered rational explanations for natural phenomena like rainbows and fossils, and he criticized the high social status given to athletes over wise individuals. According to modern scholars, Xenophanes represents a crucial step from mythological storytelling toward philosophical inquiry. His ideas about a non-anthropomorphic god and his use of observation to explain the natural world influenced later major philosophers like Parmenides, Empedocles, Plato, and Aristotle. His life and fragmented writings provide a key early example of critical, rational thought about divinity, nature, and society.

Works (5)

- Ἐπίγραμμα · [Epigram](#) · 4 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα Σίλλοι καὶ Περὶ φύσεως · [Fragments Silli and-Nature](#) · 56 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα · [On Piety and Festivity](#) · 12 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα · [Symposium and Piety Fragments](#) · 47 passages
- Μαρτυρίαι · [Testimonies](#) · 55 passages

Other Presocratic Authors

- Ἀλκμαίων ὁ Κροτωνιάτης · [Alcmaeon of Croton](#) · 2 works
- Ἀναξαγόρας ὁ Κλαζομένιος · [Anaxagoras of Clazomenae](#) · 2 works
- Ἀναξίμανδρος ὁ Μιλήσιος · [Anaximander of Miletus](#) · 2 works
- Ἀναξίμενης ὁ Μιλήσιος · [Anaximenes of Miletus](#) · 2 works
- Ἀναξιμένους τοῦ Μιλησίου Ἐπιστολαί (Ψευδο-Ἀναξίμενης) · [Anaximenes-pseudo Miletus Letters](#) · 1 work

- Ἀρχέλαος ὁ Μιλήσιος ὁ Ἀθηναῖος · Archelaus of Miletus · 2 works
- Κλεόβουλος ὁ Λίνδιος · Cleobulus of Lindos I · 1 work
- Δημόκριτος ὁ Ἀβδηρίτης · Democritus of Abdera · 2 works
- Διογένης ὁ Ἀπολλωνιάτης · Diogenes of Apollonia · 2 works
- Ἐμπεδοκλῆς ὁ Ἀκραγαντίνος · Empedocles of Acragas · 3 works
- Ἡράκλειτος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · Heraclitus of Ephesus · 2 works
- Ἡράκλειτος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · Heraclitus of Ephesus II · 1 work